

Latin America's Revolutionary Turn: From Populism to Revolution

In the aftermath of World War II, Latin America faced mounting challenges. Population boomed while industrialization stalled, creating a perfect storm of urban poverty and social unrest. Millions migrated to cities seeking opportunity but instead found desperation.

The story of Carolina Maria de Jesús, a Brazilian shantytown writer, embodied this struggle. As conditions deteriorated, a revolutionary sentiment began to take hold across the region. Many Latin Americans came to believe that only radical change could address the fundamental inequalities plaguing their societies.



Populism: A New Political Coalition



Mass-Based Movement

Postwar populism emerged as an urban, nationalist movement that wasn't Marxist but appealed broadly to middle and working classes.



Tactical Approach

Leaders used mass rallies and radio broadcasts to criticize traditional oligarchs while promising material gains without sparking class warfare.



Democratic Expansion

Women gained suffrage, voting age requirements were lowered, and literacy tests were eliminated, broadening political participation.





Economic Visions: Breaking the Dependency Cycle



US Economic Model

American economists advocated for "comparative advantage" - returning to raw material exports.



Nationalist Vision

Latin American leaders favored industrialization to break economic dependence.



Dependency Theory

ECLA and Raúl Prebisch proposed that Latin America was trapped in a "peripheral" role to the industrial "center."

Populism in Practice: Argentina's Peronism

1

Rise to Power

Juan Perón rose through labor leadership, becoming president in 1946 by promoting unionization and social welfare programs.

2

Evita's Influence

Eva Perón became a beloved figure through charity work and populist rhetoric, helping pass women's suffrage in 1947 while reinforcing traditional gender roles.

3

Peronist Ideology

The movement combined nationalism, state economic intervention, and anti-oligarchy rhetoric that resonated with working classes.

4

Downfall

Economic failures and conflicts with the Catholic Church eventually led to Perón's exile from Argentina in 1955.



Populism Across Latin America: Brazil and Mexico

Brazil Under Vargas

Getúlio Vargas returned to power democratically in 1950 but committed suicide in 1954, symbolizing failed promises to Brazil's poor. The construction of Brasília in 1960 represented modernist aspirations that often ignored widespread poverty.



Mexico's PRI Dominance

The Institutional Revolutionary Party (PRI) monopolized power while promoting nationalism and economic growth. Reforms like ejidos supported urban living standards, but despite industrial development, inequality remained deeply entrenched in Mexican society.



Colombia: When Populism Fails

Gaitán's Assassination

Jorge Eliécer Gaitán's murder in 1948 prevented a strong populist movement from forming.

Failed Restoration

General Gustavo Rojas Pinilla attempted to restore order through populist methods but ultimately resigned in 1957.



La Violencia Erupts

His death triggered intense rural civil conflict between Liberals and Conservatives.

Rural Displacement

Land grabs and forced relocations created decades of instability.



Cold War Politics: US Influence in Latin America

Economic Priorities

After 1947, US aid focused primarily on Europe through the Marshall Plan, leaving Latin American development needs largely unaddressed.

Military Alliances

The Rio Pact of 1947 established a permanent military alliance system that reinforced US security interests in the hemisphere.

Support for Dictators

US business interests and diplomacy often favored authoritarian leaders like Trujillo, Pérez Jiménez, and Somoza who suppressed leftist or nationalist movements.

Anti-Communist Doctrine

The 1954 Declaration of Caracas effectively equated all Marxist thought with foreign invasion, setting the stage for interventions.

Contrasting Paths: Guatemala and Bolivia



Guatemala: Reform and Intervention

Presidents Arévalo and Arbenz promoted land reform and labor rights, but when Arbenz expropriated United Fruit land and received Czech weapons, the CIA orchestrated his overthrow in 1954.



Bolivia: Revolution with US Support

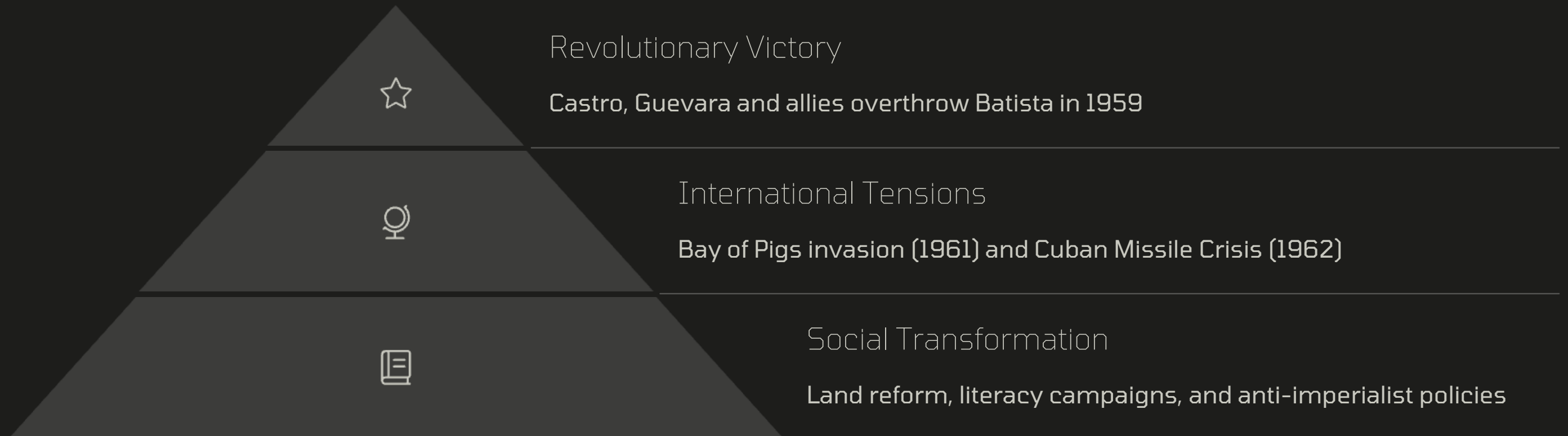
The National Revolutionary Movement took power in 1952, nationalizing tin mines and redistributing land to Indigenous farmers.



Different US Responses

While Guatemala faced intervention, Bolivia received US aid and support, demonstrating two contrasting Cold War approaches.

The Cuban Revolution: A Hemispheric Turning Point



The Cuban Revolution represented a watershed moment in Latin American history. Fidel Castro, Raúl Castro, and Che Guevara's successful overthrow of the Batista regime in 1959 established a revolutionary government with ambitious goals of land reform, ending imperialism, and promoting social justice.

Revolutionary Legacy: From Cuba to Liberation Theology



Cuba's Revolutionary Model

Cuba became a symbol of anti-imperialism and a hub for literacy, healthcare, and revolutionary culture. It inspired guerrilla movements across Latin America, though it also restricted civil liberties under authoritarian control.



Liberation Theology

Inspired by Paulo Freire's "consciousness raising," the 1968 Medellín Conference called for a "preferential option for the poor." This movement blended Catholic faith with revolutionary goals, though it faced conservative backlash, particularly from Pope John Paul II.



A New Generation

The 1950s-60s marked a profound shift as populism gave way to revolution and nationalism took on a Marxist edge. Across Latin America, a new generation found both hope and fear in revolutionary ideals that would shape the region for decades to come.